



Lost in paradise: Besides training young athletes, Klaus was also drawn to India by a desire to visit the Himalayas — a fascination rooted in his childhood in Oberschlettenbach, a village nourished by mountain springs (centre) and surrounded by forested hills. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

then just before I left, I went to the Rohtang Pass near Manali. But there's a lot I haven't been able to do. I want to see the Nubra Valley and Spiti. Maybe I'll do it this time," he says.

Impressive as these heights are, equally impressive are the ones he scaled together with Neeraj.

When he arrived in India in 2018, Klaus wasn't specifically meant to work with the then 20-year-old. "At that time, Neeraj was training under Uwe Hohn. When I first came, I was working with the other athletes — Shivpal, Annu (Rani) and others. One day there was a meeting with (Lalit) Bhanot, the Chief Coach, the president of the AFI, and Uwe and Neeraj. And then, at the end of the meeting, Neeraj said, 'I won't work anymore with Coach Uwe.'

"At that time, I wasn't even aware that there was any issue between the two of them. They had just won the Commonwealth Games and Asian

Games together. But not long after that, in the spring of 2019, Neeraj and I started working together," Klaus remembers.

The early days of their partnership coincided with a series of injuries for Neeraj, who eventually had to undergo surgery on his elbow that kept him out of action for most of 2019. For all of Neeraj's talent, Klaus admits he wasn't thinking about Olympic gold at that point. "At the time we started working together, we were mostly focusing on his rehab. So, we did a lot of gymnastics work. That's when I got an idea of just how well coordinated he was. He had a lot of endurance as well, which I saw during his training sessions in South Africa.

"But did I think he would become Olympic champion in Tokyo? No. Of course not. I thought he would make the final, but I didn't think he was going to win gold. The goal back then was to make the final, then get

to the last three throws and see how that went. I think I only really started believing it when he made that throw of 87m in the Olympic final and there was no one who was getting close," he says.

But it wasn't Neeraj's physical attributes that stood out to Klaus back then. "Neeraj wasn't the strongest. There are other throwers who were much stronger than him, but the stronger he got, the poorer his throws became — and that was because he stopped using his brain. One thing that always stood out about Neeraj was just how professional he was. He has a few people he really trusts. There was this friendship he had with (physio) Ishan, but it was built on professionalism.

"He was always on time, always prepared. He never forgot anything. Just a very sharp person with a very sharp mind. He was very fixated on the javelin throw. He knew almost